High Schools Should Start Later, but Districts Must Plan for the Bus Bill

[needs: student name] [needs: course and instructor, English 102] [needs: due date]

High schools should start later in the morning. The evidence in the studies reviewed here shows a clear benefit in attendance, no sign of harm to test scores, and one real cost, transportation. That cost is large enough that a district should budget for it before it moves the first bell. It is not large enough to block the change.

The strongest evidence concerns attendance. Rivera (2021) followed 4,200 students in one district after the first bell moved 45 minutes later. Attendance rose from 91.4% to 93.5%, a gain of 2.1 percentage points. A student who is not in the building cannot learn from the lesson, so a rise in attendance is a rise in the time students have with their teachers. The gain was not spread evenly. Grades 11 and 12 improved by 3.0 percentage points (Rivera, 2021). Older students gained the most.

Critics may reply that a later start should show up in grades, and the evidence here does not show that it does. Chen and Okoye (2022) studied 3,900 students and found that test scores did not change significantly in the first year after a later start. The mean difference was 0.4 points on a 100-point scale ($p = .62$). This result deserves a fair reading. It does not show that later starts hurt learning, since scores held steady while attendance rose. It also does not show that scores will stay flat. The authors say longer follow-up is needed (Chen & Okoye, 2022). A district that adopts a later start should therefore track scores for several years and report them to families.

The cost side is the hardest part of the case for supporters. Brooks (2023) sampled 15 districts that moved to later starts. Eleven of them needed an extra bus tier, and transportation costs rose by an average of 6.2% of the transportation budget. Most districts in that sample paid more, and a plan that ignores this will fail in its first budget cycle.

Still, a 6.2% rise in one budget line is a limited and predictable cost. It is a known number that a district can plan for, and it buys a measurable gain. Four of the 15 districts in Brooks's (2023) sample needed no extra tier at all, so the cost can sometimes be avoided with careful scheduling. The attendance gain of 2.1 points, and 3.0 points among the oldest students, is the benefit that cost buys. The studies do not compare the two figures in dollars, so the case rests on the direction of the evidence and not on a calculated return.

The three studies also share a limit. Each looks at one district or a small group of districts, and the test-score study covers only the first year. A district should treat their findings as a reason to try the change and to measure it, not as a guarantee. What the studies support is a modest, documented benefit with a modest, documented price.

My position follows from that. High schools should start later, and districts should do it in steps. First, they should price the bus changes before the vote, using the 6.2% average as a planning figure. Second, they should publish attendance and test data each year. If attendance rises as it did for Rivera's (2021) students and scores hold steady as they did for Chen and Okoye's (2022), the district keeps the schedule. If scores fall, the district has the data to adjust it. Families and teachers can then judge the change on published numbers instead of on opinion, and the district can say plainly what the later bell cost and what it returned.

References

Brooks, D. (2023). Bus schedules under later bell times. *Fictional Transportation Review, 9*(2), 101-117.

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Rivera, M. (2021). Later start times and attendance. *Journal of Fictional Education, 12*(3), 44-58.